

Chapter 172-1

As spring was about to arrive, even the wind carried warmth.

Xu Qingzhu's words, carried by the wind, fell into Liang Shi's ears, making them feel ticklish.

Liang Shi raised her head and unexpectedly met Xu Qingzhu's gaze, who had been staring at her intently.

Their eyes met.

Those light brown pupils reflected not only tonight's hazy moon but also the person she loved.

Liang Shi's gaze wandered, glancing around randomly.

After a moment, she changed the subject, lowering her head to pick up the food. "Aren't I already being supported by Teacher Xu?"

Xu Qingzhu knew she didn't want to talk about this matter and shrugged indifferently. "You know that's not what I mean."

"Then what is it?" Liang Shi's tone was teasing. "Are you planning to confront Dongheng head-on?"

Xu Qingzhu pouted. "It won't come to that."

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi glanced at her sideways. "Won't come to that? Teacher Xu, those words really hurt my feelings."

Xu Qingzhu laughed softly. "What else? If I clash with Dongheng, that means clashing with Big Brother. What are you thinking? Should I yield to him or should I yield to him? Sister-in-law is about to give birth. It would be too underhanded of me to do that now. What would you do if your little niece hated you?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"Isn't she your niece too?" Liang Shi poked her shoulder with the other end of her chopsticks.

Xu Qingzhu picked up some food with her chopsticks and brought it to her mouth, answering with a smile. "She is."

And just like that, the topic was easily set aside.

Xu Qingzhu knew Liang Shi had her own plans. Liang Shi knew Xu Qingzhu respected her thoughts.

That was enough.

The production crew was still filming as usual. Zhao Ying still had some scenes left to shoot.

It would probably go until past 3 AM.

Zhao Ying was over there going through the script with the director, rehearsing scenes. She yawned twice, and her assistant handed her coffee.

When she saw Xu Qingzhu, she raised her hand to wave hello but didn't have time to come over.

Xu Qingzhu handed the milk tea she'd bought to her assistant, but Zhao Ying said she was watching her weight. She was even drinking sugar-free coffee and didn't dare touch things like milk tea at all.

Things were busy over there. Liang Shi was too tired to move, so Xu Qingzhu sat outside with her.

The two of them sat together chatting casually.

From Yu Wan's due date to the recent trending topics, Xu Qingzhu teased, "Teacher Liang, you don't even need to investigate to know who's targeting you."

"What can I do about it?" Liang Shi said. "Does this count as being punished for possessing a treasure?"¹

"I don't think so," Xu Qingzhu said. "It's just that your opponent is too weak."

Liang Shi: "?"

"I don't count as being punished for possessing a treasure?" Liang Shi asked her.

Xu Qingzhu stared at her carefully, then shook her head after a moment. "What treasure are you possessing? I'd believe it more if you said you yourself are the treasure."

Liang Shi: "....."

"I don't understand her," Liang Shi said. "She pretty much has everything she wants now, right? Why does she still have to do this? If things really go wrong... she can't always have Qiu Zimin clean up after her, can she?"

"It's normal that you don't understand," Xu Qingzhu shrugged. "Why would you try to understand the thoughts of a bad person?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"Just discussing it normally," Liang Shi said. "There are so many people on the trending topics cursing at me... all saying I'm a resource mooch."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow. "Why not just prove them right? Otherwise, they'd be cursing for nothing."

Liang Shi: ".....Go away."

Liang Shi raised her hand and lightly flicked her forehead. "Am I that useless in your heart?"

"How could that be?" Xu Qingzhu covered her forehead, then clung to her arm and rested her head on her shoulder. Her cool voice was very low, yet especially captivating: "Please, you're Liang Shi. How could you be useless?"

"Then for such a small matter, you want to step in and solve it for me," Liang Shi said. "Do you think I don't have the ability?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu's eyes were bright, and her voice softened too. "Back when you helped me deal with Bai Weiwei and Chen Liuying, that was enough to show your abilities. But you're filming right now and don't have time to spare. What's wrong with me helping you solve it? Can't I?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"Teacher Liang, this isn't like you," Xu Qingzhu teased. "Are you feeling inferior?"

Liang Shi: "?"

"How could I be?" Liang Shi lightly pinched her face. "My wife being capable is something to be proud of. I don't have that kind of pointless pride. It's just that I've seen too many situations like this. Using capital to silence people doesn't work. The person involved stepping in doesn't work either. Even if being a resource mooch is confirmed, it still doesn't work. The best way to fight back is with your work. When your achievements match your resources, it won't matter what anyone says."

Xu Qingzhu's eyes immediately lit up. While Liang Shi was still thinking, she leaned over and kissed her. "Mwah~"

Complete with sound effects.

Liang Shi immediately covered her face and instinctively looked around.

Xu Qingzhu watched her with a smile. Liang Shi whispered in a panic, "What are you doing?"

"What's wrong?" Xu Qingzhu said. "Is it illegal to kiss you?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Her ears immediately turned red.

Xu Qingzhu rested both hands on her legs. "Then call the police."

Liang Shi grabbed her hands, her smile both indulgent and helpless, and said softly, "There are so many people here."

"It's legal," Xu Qingzhu said. "I just kissed your face..."

Liang Shi widened her eyes. "And you still want to..."

Before she could finish, Xu Qingzhu leaned forward and kissed her lips.

Liang Shi instinctively licked her lips, wanting to laugh but holding it back, her entire face flushed red.

Xu Qingzhu rubbed her forehead helplessly. "How are you so easily embarrassed?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi covered her face. "There are so many people here~"

Xu Qingzhu pursed her lips and leaned forward to kiss her again, but only kissed the back of her hand. Liang Shi also lowered her hand and warned Xu Qingzhu in a small voice, "Watch yourself."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow. "Teacher Liang, are you keeping someone on the side in the production crew? Why are you so scared?"

"No." Liang Shi immediately explained. "There are so many people here... You... I... We... Never mind."

Liang Shi didn't know how to explain. It was just that the atmosphere in the crew was very delicate.

Last time when Xu Qingzhu came to see her and just kissed her on the cheek, after Xu Qingzhu left, she was teased for a long time.

Every time everyone went "Ohhh," Liang Shi's face would turn red.

Being intimate in public was something Liang Shi still couldn't quite get used to.

She stood up and pulled Xu Qingzhu to leave, but Xu Qingzhu refused.

Liang Shi turned back and leaned close to her. "Let's go, back to the hotel."

"Why?" Xu Qingzhu asked, tilting her head up.

Liang Shi's throat moved slightly. She cleared her throat softly, leaned over, and said in a low voice, "I want to kiss you properly."

Footnotes:

¹ **"Being punished for possessing a treasure" (懷璧其罪):** A Chinese idiom meaning "the crime of carrying a jade," referring to how possessing something valuable can bring trouble or make one a target. It comes from the story of someone who was killed because others coveted their precious jade. Here, Liang Shi is suggesting she's being targeted because of her resources/connections.

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The hotel room's lights were dim yellow. The moment they entered, Liang Shi hooked the door closed with her foot and pressed Xu Qingzhu directly against it.

Yet Xu Qingzhu still asked her, "Are you being ambiguous with someone in your production crew? Why are you so scared?"

Liang Shi's forehead rested against hers, her breathing somewhat uneven, her heartbeat accelerating.

"How could that be?" Liang Shi confessed honestly. "Last time you just kissed me once, and after you left, everywhere I went people were looking at me. I was almost embarrassed to death. Every time I was filming, I kept thinking of you. That scene I could have passed in one take, but because of you, I had to do it five times."

Xu Qingzhu's eyes darted around. "Really?"

"Yes." Liang Shi bit her lower lip, her lips glistening. Backlit, her figure looked slender yet still beautiful.

Her slender hand rested on the back of Xu Qingzhu's neck, fingers threading into the ends of her hair.

Liang Shi tried to regulate her breathing, but it only grew faster.

Along with her heartbeat, which also quickened.

Xu Qingzhu stared straight at her. "You're not lying to me?"

"Why would I lie to you? My little ancestor."¹ Liang Shi's voice was husky. "You haven't even done anything and I'm already losing my composure. Where would I have the energy to be ambiguous with someone else?"

"Who knows." Xu Qingzhu scoffed lightly. "Who knows what you're thinking?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, wanting to explain something but didn't say it. Her hand moved slightly upward, gently tilting Xu Qingzhu's beautiful neck back, and lowered her head to meet her lips.

Amidst the haze, she mumbled, "This is what I'm thinking."

Simply, I want to kiss you.

Although not under everyone's watchful eyes.

But in this hidden moment, all her love had nowhere to hide.

Footnotes:

¹ **"My little ancestor" (祖宗):** A Chinese term of endearment used when someone is being demanding or difficult to please. Literally meaning "ancestor," it's used affectionately to express "you're so hard to serve" in a doting way.

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Liang Shi didn't pay much attention to the online comments, even though the public opinion kept fermenting.

By the time she finished filming *Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo*, the comments about her still hadn't died down.

Labels like "resource mooch" and "marketing personality" were all placed on her.

Even her previous red dress look trending was said to have been deliberate.

Most critically, when people searched for her online, they couldn't find anything—just a few ambiguous exposés with no substantial content.

Nothing more than claims that she used to have a bad personality, her family had some money, but now she'd fallen on hard times—the whole "fallen heiress" script.

Liang Shi was actually quite surprised that the things the original owner had done before hadn't been dug up.

According to her speculation, they should have been dragged out during this wave of negative press to muddy the waters. It wasn't until she received a private message that she discovered it was Liang Xinzhou's doing.

Because Liang Shi had told him before that she didn't want people to know about her identity as the Liang family's Third Miss when entering the entertainment industry, and she didn't want those past incidents to be exposed, Liang Xinzhou had handled all of it for her.

He had even erased her connection to Dongheng.

When capital entered the arena, nothing survived.

After learning this, Liang Shi sent Liang Xinzhou a message: [Thank you, Big Brother.]

With Yu Wan's due date approaching, after *Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo* wrapped, Liang Shi went with Xu Qingzhu to visit Yu Wan at the hospital. At that time, Yu Wan was watching Gu Yixue's viral movie *"Rose Heart Fire,"* watching with great interest.

Since she had nothing to do recently, she had started her internet surfing life at the hospital. She knew Liang Shi had acted in Gu Yixue's new movie, which was about to be released.

Liang Shi sat there peeling an apple for Yu Wan, and Yu Wan asked her, "Is Quella really that beautiful? Is she more beautiful in person or in photos?"

"In person," Liang Shi said. "She could play the female lead and it wouldn't break immersion at all."

"That's really impressive," Yu Wan said. "I've long heard that the Gu family's daughter is a rare figure among Betas, but I've never met her."

"I'll introduce you someday," Liang Shi said with a light laugh.

"You two are that close?" Yu Wan paused, then laughed. "Well, that makes sense. After all, you're the kind of people who would crash a wedding together."

Liang Shi: "....."

That incident had probably spread throughout high society circles.

Who knows how long Gu Yixue had been the subject of after-dinner gossip.

But the storm over that matter had passed.

Recently, she heard that Gu Yixue was planning to shoot a new movie—apparently a period martial arts film. Another brand new challenge.

Liang Shi chatted with Yu Wan for a while, then Sun Meirou arrived with Ling Dang.

Ling Dang looked dejected. Liang Shi thought she was unhappy because school had started and asked what was wrong.

Ling Dang pouted. "Zhou Caihong is so disloyal. She just transferred schools like that. How outrageous!"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi coaxed Ling Dang for a while.

Xu Qingzhu had only come in her spare time. She occasionally chimed in during their conversation, but before long she started feeling drowsy. Her body also made it difficult for her to sit for too long, so they didn't stay long before leaving the hospital.

Before leaving, Xu Qingzhu happened to run into Liang Xinzhou, who had just rushed over from the company, and they chatted briefly.

Calling it a chat, it was more like a complaint, or even a warning.

"You know who's behind all that stuff online, right?" Xu Qingzhu said. "Right now, like Liang Shi, I can still tolerate it. But if this continues, I really won't be polite."

"How do you plan to be impolite?" Liang Xinzhou asked with a smile.

Xu Qingzhu frowned. "Does Big Brother think I'm joking?"

Liang Xinzhou shook his head. "That someone can protect A-Shi like this—I think that's very good."

Xu Qingzhu was immediately mollified by his words, but she still said, "I don't know what I might do, but I'll give her a taste of her own medicine. Everyone now knows she's the long-lost miss of Dongheng Group, so her every word and action currently represents Dongheng. Big Brother, you know A-Shi has always respected you. I also don't want to make things difficult for you."

Liang Xinzhou nodded. "Don't worry about me or Dongheng. I have my own ways of dealing with things."

"You... won't stop it?" Xu Qingzhu furrowed her brows slightly.

She had thought that after telling Liang Xinzhou, he would stop it at the source.

But Liang Xinzhou shook his head. "She represents Dongheng? She doesn't have that qualification yet. Do you remember what happened with Ling Dang before? I still have some doubts, so I need to wait for her to do something before I can find evidence. If you walk by the river often enough, how can you not get your shoes wet?"¹

Xu Qingzhu was momentarily stunned, then after a long while smiled helplessly. "Alright then."

Liang Xinzhou didn't let her act recklessly either, but rather told her to be careful and cautious. "If it really is her doing, you don't need to be polite, and you don't need to worry about me. But if it hasn't been confirmed yet that she did it, I hope you'll show some mercy. Wan'er is about to give birth, and Xinhe isn't someone who can handle pressure, so..."

He didn't finish the rest, but he was asking Xu Qingzhu to leave some face.

But Xu Qingzhu just smiled gracefully. "Big Brother, am I really that capable? It won't go that far."

"I would never underestimate anyone from the Sheng family." Liang Xinzhou shrugged. "Especially someone who could bring Minghui back from the dead in half a year. Qingzhu, you really are very capable."

Xu Qingzhu was unexpectedly praised and quite pleased. "Suddenly I feel full of motivation."

Liang Xinzhou laughed softly. "Qingzhu, A-Shi has a bit of a childish nature, but she's a good person. The Liang family's matters are the Liang family's—they have nothing to do with her personally. Live your lives well and don't let these things affect you."

"She might not have been very good before, perhaps because my mother twisted her personality. But now that she's with you, she's really, truly good. I can always see traces of her childhood self in her." Liang Xinzhou's voice was softer than ever. He turned to look at Xu Qingzhu. "If she does anything wrong, come tell me and I'll discipline her for you."

Xu Qingzhu heard a feeling of "entrusting an orphan"² in his words.

"What do you mean by this?" Xu Qingzhu asked. "Big Brother, this isn't like you."

"Just treat it as me having had too much to drink." Liang Xinzhou raised his hand to his forehead. "She only has you left now. Take good care of each other."

Xu Qingzhu was startled, then suddenly understood what Liang Xinzhou meant.

Because when it came down to it, Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe were still members of the Liang family—Qiu Zimin's sons. No matter how much they cared for Liang Shi, they couldn't cross Dongheng's bottom line.

During holidays and festivals, there would be no opportunity to be with Liang Shi.

In the end, Liang Shi would be left alone.

So apart from her, Liang Shi had no family.

Yet Liang Xinzhou truly cared for Liang Shi. He hoped Liang Shi would be well, hoped she could still have a home, have someone who loved her.

This coincided with some of Xu Qingzhu's own thoughts.

So Xu Qingzhu took the opportunity to ask Liang Xinzhou, "Then do you know that Liang Shi actually has other family? Where are her birth parents?"

"I've asked my mother and looked into it myself." Liang Xinzhou shook his head. "Couldn't find anything."

Xu Qingzhu tried to detect any trace of lying in his expression but found only sincerity.

He truly didn't know.

Xu Qingzhu also breathed a sigh of relief.

Footnotes:

¹ **"If you walk by the river often enough, how can you not get your shoes wet?"** (常在河邊走，哪有不濕鞋的): A Chinese proverb meaning that if someone keeps doing bad things, they will eventually get caught or face consequences. Similar to "crime doesn't pay" or "if you play with fire, you'll get burned."

² **"Entrusting an orphan"** (托孤): A classical Chinese concept referring to entrusting the care of one's child or loved one to another person, typically done when facing death or permanent separation. It's a very serious and emotional gesture of trust.

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Xu Qingzhu was very afraid that Liang Shi had been living in a fabricated dream all along.

That Qiu Zimin treated her badly was already an established fact that could be accepted. But if she were also being deceived by Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe, Liang Shi would probably be very hurt.

Fortunately, Liang Xinzhou was someone who could see things clearly and who genuinely cared for Liang Shi.

Liang Xinhe was also okay—though a bit soft-hearted, he wouldn't do anything bad to Liang Shi.

Moreover, because of Liang Xinran's appearance, Liang Xinhe had been even nicer to Liang Shi, occasionally buying things and sending them to the production crew, as if announcing to the entire crew—Liang Shi has backing!

It was actually rather cute.

During the filming of *Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo*, Liang Shi had also seen Liang Wanwan once.

She had cut her hair short and didn't mention Chen Mian at all, only saying she had won a national award and wanted to treat Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu to dinner.

They had Huaiyang cuisine for dinner—sweet-flavored.¹

However, after a few drinks, Liang Wanwan became tipsy. Afterward, she squatted alone on the Yujiang Bridge, holding onto the railing and gazing at the river.

Liang Shi was still too slow to notice, and it was only after Xu Qingzhu gave her a hint that she understood.

So Liang Wanwan liked Chen Mian.

But on the day Chen Mian asked her to pick up Liang Wanwan, they must have had a falling out.

Later, she heard that Chen Mian had stopped going to the media school altogether.

Chen Mian was actually a responsible person. Having agreed to do something for Gu Yixue, even when she was in bad shape and couldn't paint, she would lock herself at home and keep painting, ensuring she delivered the artwork to Gu Yixue on time.

But she heard that Chen Mian had abandoned that school project halfway through.

All because of Liang Wanwan.

Liang Shi didn't know what to say. She could only sigh that everyone was trapped in this besieged city of emotions, unable to escape.²

Not two days after *Mo Mo Mo Mo Mo* wrapped, *Journey of the Heart* began its promotional period.

Because this was Gu Yixue's first time entering the domestic market, it was also her first time following domestic promotional procedures.

Actually, according to domestic procedures, the pre-release buzz should have started a month before the movie's release, then theater scheduling would be determined based on audience expectations, and so on.

Gu Yixue was obviously late, but she hadn't planned on making much money from this movie anyway. It wasn't a commercial film to begin with.

With less than a week until release, the *Journey of the Heart* main creative team met again and began promotional screenings at various universities.

Because it was a work that had already been nominated for an international competition, people's standards were higher when evaluating it.

Yet in the rating systems of many strict and renowned film critics, it could score 8 points, which was considered very high.

Liang Shi's acting was also praised among them—she didn't just act on the surface, nor was she afraid to get her face dirty for the sake of her image. She played the role exactly as it should be, and even so, she didn't lose her aesthetic appeal. It was a rare kind of bone-structure beauty.

However, the flood of positive reviews online made audiences who hadn't yet seen the movie develop a rebellious attitude.

[This is all manufactured, right? Can you even trust movie bloggers these days?]

[Are you guys praising it just because you got paid? How good can someone's acting be in their first role?]

[As long as you pay them, will they even praise green-screen acting as amazing?]

[Seriously, can no one dig up Liang Shi's backer? This is fucking making me sick.]

[I strongly suspect she slept her way up through Quella.]

[If you want to criticize her, criticize her, but leave Quella out of it. A young prodigy director and screenwriter whose looks rival popular drama actresses—even if she were with Quella, that would be in the realm of romance, not sleeping one's way up.]

[.....]

Then somehow comments appeared saying that Quella and Liang Shi were in a secret relationship, and someone had even filmed videos of them drinking together and going to bars together.

They looked like they had a good relationship.

The movie hadn't even been released yet, and it had gotten another wave of attention because of Liang Shi alone.

Then the general public rebelled again.

[Is this some kind of celebrity? Does she have any notable works?]

[Honestly, the bar for your industry is way too low. You can get by just on looks?]

[Wasn't her red dress look just riding on Yang Shuyan's coattails? Someone who markets herself by clinging to various celebrities—can she be anything decent?]

[Isn't this movie an art film? It's trending every day—is the director that rich?]

[It's all to promote Liang Shi, right? Another fraud after YSY.]

[To the comment above, YYSY³, YSY actually has achievements. She shouldn't be compared to someone who's being hyped as a goddess based on just one set of photos and taking out loans to become a Best Actress. You're really elevating a fraud here.]

[So, don't you guys get penalized for using abbreviations? Can someone explain what all this stuff above means?]

[To be fair, Yang Shuyan.]

[.....]

After seeing all these chaotic comments, Gu Yixue sent the ridiculous screenshots to Liang Shi and asked in surprise: [Is the domestic film environment really like this now?]

Liang Shi: [...As you can see.]

Gu Yixue: [Since when do you have to dig into the actors and director before watching a movie?]

Liang Shi: [So when were we photographed?]

Gu Yixue: [Who knows.]

Liang Shi then asked Gu Yixue if she wanted to clarify.

She herself was used to this kind of thing in the domestic entertainment industry. She'd experienced even worse before.

So right now, she was operating on the principle of "if it's trending, it's free money."

If there was buzz, ride it. If there was a trending topic, latch onto it. Try to promote the movie without spending a cent. When dealing with Chen Liuying before, she had been thinking about hiring water armies, but now she couldn't be bothered to control anything.

Who needed water armies? Drama generated buzz.

Those film critics who had seen their movie and their fans were their free water army.

Liang Shi had already reported this matter to Xu Qingzhu, and Xu Qingzhu agreed, just telling her to handle it as she saw fit.

But Gu Yixue was also married, so she needed to consider Gu Yixue's situation too.

As it turned out, before Gu Yixue could even reply to her, she had already posted a clarification.

@Quella: Married. Do not disturb.

The person herself came out to refute the rumors.

And Liang Shi immediately reposted her Weibo:

@Liang Shi: Not with me. No need to speculate wildly.

Online, things finally quieted down briefly.

But unexpectedly, the third episode of *"Let's Go, Right Now"* and the release of *Journey of the Heart* were scheduled for the same day, just at different times.

Footnotes:

¹ **Huaiyang cuisine (淮揚菜):** One of the four major Chinese cuisines, originating from the Huai'an and Yangzhou regions of Jiangsu Province. It's known for its delicate, slightly sweet flavors and emphasis on fresh ingredients and precise knife work.

² **"Besieged city of emotions" (感情的圍城):** A reference to the famous Chinese novel "Fortress Besieged" (圍城) by Qian Zhongshu, which uses the metaphor of a besieged city to describe marriage and relationships—those outside want in, while those inside want out. Here it's used to describe being trapped in complicated emotional situations.

³ **"YYSY" (有一說一):** Chinese internet slang abbreviation meaning "to be fair" or "speaking objectively." The commenter is using abbreviations that confuse another user.

Chapter 172-5

Journey of the Heart was positioned as an art film, so on the first day, it had very few screenings.

The first showing was at 9 AM. They hadn't deliberately chosen a meaningful time—it was just released among the many other films.

But because the subject matter was relatively fresh, and Liang Shi's looks were quite good, the poster had a visual advantage among all the films, so some people went to see it.

On the first day, the response was mediocre.

Far from matching "*Let's Go, Right Now.*"

The previous episode's preview had pixelated Liang Shi, but since today's episode was airing, Liang Shi naturally had to promote it with a hashtag. The copy was sent to her by her manager; she just edited it a bit and posted it. She herself was more focused on developments with *Journey of the Heart*.

Unexpectedly, the moment she posted her promotional Weibo, the comment section was invaded.

[Why is it you? Is there some behind-the-scenes manipulation?]

[Resource mooch, get lost.]

[How can you be so shameless?]

[.....]

Almost no positive comments. Her pinned Weibo post was the promotion for *Journey of the Heart*, and her background image was her favorite set of red dress photos from when she went viral.

Netizens cursed all they wanted, cursing her onto the trending list, but her follower count just kept increasing.

With nothing having aired yet, Liang Shi really couldn't defend herself. She could only lie flat and accept the mockery.

Meanwhile, *Journey of the Heart* scored 9.8 on a certain movie platform.

Netizens were shocked.

[How many water armies did they buy?]

[Wait, a Republic-era romance film can score this high? How long has it been since domestic entertainment has seen a good drama?]

[Is a double female lead film really that shippable? This movie has way too many water armies.]

[.....]

No one believed it.

Even though it had been nominated for an international film competition.

But for the domestic audience, it was just an art film made by a director for self-appreciation. What kind of quality could it have? An incomprehensible script plus trippy camerawork, with a bunch of film critics praising it incoherently—it was just self-indulgent emotional gratification.

Works that could resonate with audiences weren't things these artsy types could produce.

From the very beginning, audiences didn't believe in *Quella*.

But unexpectedly, because of this surreal rating, *Journey of the Heart* trended again.

Everyone refused to believe a bad film could have such a high rating, so with a challenging attitude, they decided to go to the cinema to watch it.

Planning to criticize it with solid evidence after watching.

As a result, tickets for *Journey of the Heart's* second-day screenings were completely booked. A blogger who owned a cinema posted about it, saying they were quite shocked.

Netizens were also quite shocked.

That evening, although the variety show aired, Liang Shi didn't have many shots, and her performance was ordinary. The only thing she was criticized for was directly calling Yang Shuyan by her name, which netizens and Yang Shuyan's fans said was impolite.

Then they dragged Zhao Ying into it, saying what kind of good person could hang out with Zhao Ying?

Liang Shi was already numb to this. She could only message Zhao Ying to apologize for getting her involved.

But Zhao Ying directly posted on Weibo:

@Zhao Ying: I heard Xiao Liang went to the Town of Paradise? Did you try the delicious taro mochi for me? #Let's Go Right Now#

Directly tying them to the same boat.

Liang Shi:

Zhao Ying's response to this was: There are so many people cursing at me, a few more doesn't make a difference.

Liang Shi thought, that made sense too, so she just let the netizens do their thing. After all, once you unplugged the internet cable, you couldn't see anything.

That night, she even chatted with Xu Qingzhu: "This online world is too terrifying. I'm being cyber-bullied all the time."

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly: "Then just don't look. If you think about it, there's an upside too—as long as I can't see it, they're not cursing at me."

Liang Shi: ".....That makes sense!"

However, on the second day, *Journey of the Heart's* rating continued to climb. When it opened for ratings on another platform, the score also kept rising.

Everyone's reviews were also very good.

They had originally thought it would be a cringy romance drama, but ended up being moved one after another.

[I really underestimated Liang Shi's acting. My god, that scene where she cried at the end—my heart shattered.]

[And also, Sun Chengcheng's acting is amazing too! You can't tell at all that they're complete newcomers.]

[I have to say, Quella being hailed as a genius director—she really does have skills. That atmosphere, the eye contact when they first met, that camerawork—I'm literally drooling. It stabbed right into my heart!]

[Before entering the cinema: Let me see just how good this is. After leaving the cinema: Damn! Why is this movie so good!]

[.....]

And so, the third day's screenings were also fully booked, and cinemas began adding more showtimes.

The criticism related to Liang Shi gradually disappeared.

Online, there was even a hashtag: #Apologizing to Liang Shi's Beauty and Acting Skills#.

[Sorry, I was shallow. I thought beautiful people usually couldn't act.]

[I'm shipping them so hard I could die. Is jiejie wearing colored contacts? Her eyes are really so beautiful.]

[You're not a pretty vase—you're a skilled actress! Screaming!]

[.....]

Because there were too many trending topics related to Liang Shi, she and Sun Chengcheng became completely polarized.

Sun Chengcheng's reputation was also good, but her follower growth was far behind Liang Shi's.

In just five days, Liang Shi's follower count had grown to over ten million.

While Sun Chengcheng had less than a million.

Chapter 172-6

On the first Friday after *Journey of the Heart* premiered, a company employee posted their movie ticket: [The company gave us these. Apparently everyone got one. Is this movie really good? Curious.]

Someone else asked: [We're not from the same company, are we?]

The other person replied: [No, I'm at Jiahe.]

[Wow! Respect to the big shot! A Fortune 500 company.]

[Where are you?]

[I'm at Minghui.]

[.....]

And so there was even a trending hashtag: #When Can I Get Into Jiahe#.

Netizen: [Big companies are so great. They even get free movies to watch.]

That night, Gu Yixue used her main account to like that person's Weibo, and even posted with this hashtag.

@Quella: @Jiahe, thank you Sister Shen for your support. @Shen Fenghe's Side Account

Liang Shi was shocked by her move. Watching in amazement, she messaged her: [Is this what they call hiding in plain sight?]¹

Gu Yixue: [What else?]

Liang Shi: [...I've learned something.]

Gu Yixue: [But I don't recommend learning it.]

Liang Shi: [? So what are you doing?]

Gu Yixue: [Playing with fire.]

Liang Shi: [...]

Liang Shi didn't know what Gu Yixue was planning to do, but she definitely knew what Xu Qingzhu had done.

Xu Qingzhu had bought many movie tickets to support Liang Shi.

Liang Shi didn't want to expose Xu Qingzhu to the public—to be precise, she didn't want any of her private life exposed. She didn't want people online publicly commenting on whether the two of them were a good match or not. She didn't want people going after Xu Qingzhu when she collaborated with others someday.

Xu Qingzhu wasn't someone in the industry. She didn't need to bear any of this. Liang Shi wanted to protect her family.

So Liang Shi didn't do what Gu Yixue did. She only bought two pieces of cake when she went home that night.

She sat on the sofa with Xu Qingzhu watching the variety show.

The variety show happened to be *"Let's Go, Right Now."*

Xu Qingzhu also recognized Bai Yu and laughingly shared with Liang Shi an embarrassing story about Bai Yu from Lin Luoxi's wedding day.

She said that because the older sister he grew up with was getting married, he was so sad that he cried while drinking three bottles of alcohol, then stood on the wedding stage and performed a striptease. Fortunately, he had a decent body, but Lin Luoxi went up that day and smacked him on the back of his head.

Liang Shi laughed quite hard after hearing this and said this was exactly the kind of thing Bai Yu would do.

As the variety show was nearing its end, Liang Shi suddenly received a call from her manager.

Xu Qingzhu paused the TV and turned to look at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi instinctively squeezed her fingers, and Xu Qingzhu leaned on her shoulder.

After answering, her manager asked urgently: "Just how many identities do you have?"

Liang Shi was stunned. "Huh? What's wrong?"

"Check the trending searches," Chang Hui said. "I'm going to look into who leaked this information. These leaks have been getting more and more outrageous lately."

Liang Shi hung up looking bewildered, then clicked on trending searches with the same bewildered expression. She saw that the number one trending topic was #Liang Shi Liang Xinran Real and Fake Heiress Comes to Life#.

Liang Shi:

What the hell, real and fake heiress.

The second trending topic was #Did Liang Shi Steal Liang Xinran's Life?#

Liang Shi:

The third trending topic was #Feeling Sorry for Liang Xinran#

Liang Shi exchanged a glance with Xu Qingzhu and rarely cursed out loud: "Aish², what the hell is wrong with these people."

Footnotes:

¹ **"Hiding in plain sight" (燈下黑):** A Chinese idiom literally meaning "darkness under the lamp," referring to how things closest to the light source are often the darkest and hardest to see. It means hiding something in the most obvious place where people wouldn't think to look. Here, Gu Yixue is publicly acknowledging the connection to Jiahe (through Shen Fenghe) in such an open way that people might not realize the significance.

² **"Aish" (阿西):** A mild Korean-influenced expletive commonly used in Chinese internet culture, similar to "damn" or "geez." It's a softer way of expressing frustration.